



Source: NASA

1 YEAR OF INGENUITY HELICOPTER FLYING ON MARS

This is what we call a major success

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There are some instances in the world of science where simple experiments, done with minimal expectations in terms of outcome or with no visible intention to make it a long-term project, morph into being missions that bring to the table findings that no one expected them to. The Ingenuity helicopter, which right now is busy buzzing over the surface of Mars, sending back visuals from the Red Planet, is a classic example of such an experiment.

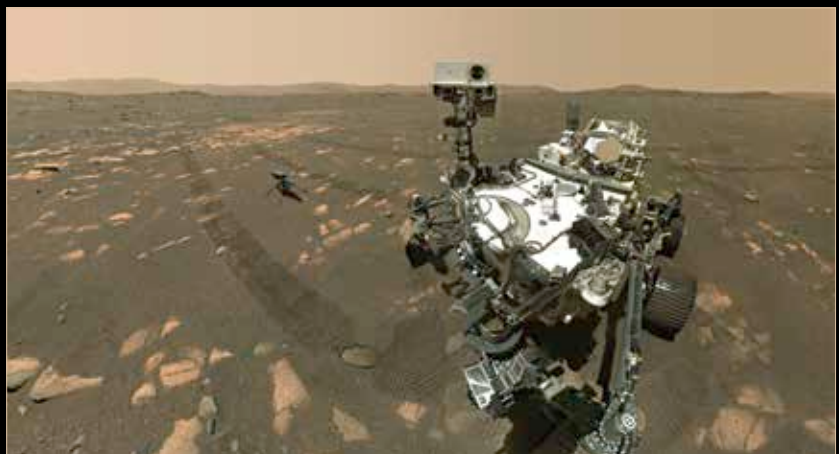
The Ingenuity Helicopter, as defined on the official page of the

copter on NASA's website, is "A technology demonstration to test the first powered flight on Mars". This statement proved the point, right? The helicopter was not supposed to do the things that it is doing right now. But whatever it is serving to us is more valuable than any planned mission would have, especially at the time this was launched.

Ingenuity helicopter was launched on July 30, 2020, as the world suffered from a raging pandemic, and landed on Mars on the February 18 the following year. Since then, it has taken off from the surface of Mars on 27 occasions and has set various unprecedented records, sent back valuable imagery, and also helped scientists gather some rather precious information.

Since its landing, where it was attached to the belly of the Perseverance rover, the first significant development in its course was when the Perseverance rover captured it in the famous selfie on the Red Planet's surface. In the image which was captured on the 46th Martian day of the mission, which on Earth was April 6, 2021, the helicopter could be seen sitting comfortably about 4 metres away from the rover. It wasn't long before it etched its name in history books by taking its first flight on April 19, 2021. It was a significant breakthrough as the helicopter climbed to a height of about 10 feet in the air, with the flight lasting 39.1 seconds. Ingenuity thus became the "first aircraft in history to make a powered, controlled flight on another planet", NASA wrote.

On the 22nd day of the same month, it lifted off for the second time and bettered its performance by covering a horizontal distance of 4 metres and climbing to 5 metres in its 51.9-second-long flight. The developments did



Ingenuity on Mars